

- Explain that the cost is really high, and you would like to save a few extra dollars every month. Some companies will throw in a free perk like extra data for a few months to keep you as a customer.

My grandparents are expert negotiators, and I'll never forget the time I was with them in the Verizon store when they insisted on keeping the plan they already had, even though it didn't officially exist anymore. Verizon wanted them to "upgrade" to the new basic plan, which included more texts and minutes than they really needed, and cost a bit more too.

After much haggling, they walked out with the same plan they had been on at the same price, and I learned this lesson that day: Nothing is ever set in stone; everything is negotiable, so don't be afraid to try it for yourself!

However, *always* get your deal or negotiation in writing before you get off the phone or leave the store. Make note of the employee's name that you talked with, as well as the date and time you talked. We ended up paying more for a data plan than promised, and couldn't prove our case because we didn't keep detailed notes of our conversation.

3. USE A "DUMB" PHONE

It seems like everyone has a smartphone these days, but are they truly necessary? Sure, the apps are great, and internet access is even better, but if push comes to shove, you can survive on a phone that does a minimum of talk and text.

I actually remember the day I upgraded to my very own Android smartphone. I was way behind my peers, which bothered me a little bit, but the savings I experienced during those years of waiting were worth much more than the pressure. Joseph and I wanted to make sure we could actually afford the phone and extra data plan *before* we made the switch, because it was quite a jump when we did!

Since my job very much relies on internet access, I can't imagine going back now, but I also know that I would if I absolutely had to. So, if money is really tight, seriously consider using a phone with fewer capabilities...at